send a clear message to Russia that there would be consequences should that country push its luck too far in southern Asia. Curzon was delighted.[116]

Perhaps the most telling event of Curzon's time as viceroy was his sponsorship of the Younghusband expedition to Tibet in 1903, for it epitomised his Russophobia, his determination to extend Britain's influence in Asia, and his tendency to act as he deemed right despite the misgivings of others. For decades, Tibet had been closed to foreigners, but by 1900 there were growing rumours from various quarters that Russia was steadily increasing its connections with that country.[117] Despite the hesitancy of London, Curzon was determined to act before Russia was able to gain a foothold in a country so close to India. He commissioned Colonel Francis Younghusband to advance into Tibet in order to force open the country to relations with Britain. Although sanctioned by Cabinet, the Younghusband mission step by step exceeded its original maxim, encouraged by an enthusiastic Curzon. The upshot of the event was that Younghusband forced his way into Lhasa and in September 1904 made the Tibetans sign a convention with Britain. Those back in London, however, believed Younghusband to have exceeded his initial commission in concluding this agreement. Despite the extraordinary physical achievement he had managed to carry out, rather than the expected hero's welcome, the colonel was censured on his return, and given only the lowest rank of knighthood, KCIE.[118]

The Tibetan mission was, however, Curzon's war, and as Arthur Balfour, prime minister of the time, complained, 'Curzon behaved as if India were an independent country, and not always a friendly one at that.'[119] Curzon's authoritative rule as viceroy was well known. As Younghusband himself noted, 'I fancy from what I saw and have heard that nobody says much against the Viceroy. He does not so much invite discussion as lay down the law and almost defiantly ask if anyone has any objection. If anyone has he is promptly squashed...'[120] So often in his career would Curzon become highly frustrated when things did not appear to be going his own way: 'I have a sort of consciousness that my arguments do not produce the smallest effect. If a Government means to sit down...no amount of kicking, even on the most sensitive spot, will induce it to rise...'[121] Curzon often complained during his time in India that the Home government was simply not listening